Lab 38: "Only high confidence" didn't quiet the reviewer

Topic 4: Prompt Engineering & Structured Output · Task 4.1: Design prompts with explicit criteria to improve precision and reduce false positives

Runs on Simulator 5: Claude Code for Continuous Integration · Run in class

Source: SkillCertPro practice exam Part 1, Q39 (unofficial third-party question)

The question

After several weeks, developers say the reviewer is noisy. Examples show comments about variable names, preferred assertion styles, and missing tests mixed with a few real null dereferences and authorization bypasses. The current prompt says, “Report only issues you are highly confident about.” What prompt change would most directly improve review usefulness?

A. Define testable report-and-skip rules that focus comments on production bugs, security flaws, broken edge cases, and subtle regressions.

B. Expand the checklist to include naming, formatting, test coverage, and architecture preferences so comments feel more comprehensive.

C. Move every automated finding into a single non-blocking summary comment so developers can scan the noise separately.

D. Keep the broad review scope and require each inline comment to include a numerical confidence score and short rationale.

Simulate it live

```
# In the browser: open Simulator 5, then Lab 38
cd labs
uv run serve.py

# In Claude Code, from the labs folder
/lab 38

# In a terminal, from simulators/simulator-5-ci-cd/
uv run casekit.py --case UC-39
```

What you should see

Vague prompt: comments on names. Criteria: the None dereference in getPrice, nothing on naming.

On stock/pricing.py the vague prompt may comment on names and style; the categorical criteria return the None dereference in getPrice and nothing about naming.

Open `simulators/simulator-5-ci-cd/evidence/` and find it yourself.

The answer

A. Testable report and skip rules: bugs and security in, style out.

The failure is not missing confidence metadata. The prompt draws no clear line between actionable correctness findings and preference comments. “High confidence” is subjective: a model can be very confident that a variable name breaks local style. Claude Code Code Review is calibrated by default for correctness (bugs that would break production), not formatting or missing tests. Make the boundary concrete: report production breakage, security risk, mishandled edge cases and regressions, and skip style, naming and preference unless the team has made them review objectives.

Why the others fail

B. Adds more of the noise developers are complaining about.

C. Repackages the noise without reducing it, and buries the real bugs.

D. Confidence scores do not define what is worth reporting, and self-reported confidence is unreliable.

Check yourself

- with categorical criteria the None dereference in getPrice is reported as a bug
- with categorical criteria no naming or style comment appears
- compare both outputs: the vague prompt is allowed to return style/naming categories and usually does

Now change one thing

Fix the loop in repo/stock/totals.py and the caller in repo/stock/jobs.py, rerun, and watch the blocking count fall.

Third-party practice material from SkillCertPro, reconstructed from a video transcript in the Tertiary Markdown Vault. Not a real exam item. Wording may differ from the original.